

King of the RING

Akshay Kumar

Log bole mujhe Bollywood star, naam mera Akshay Kumar. That's the actor singing in the soon-to-be-released *Chandni Chowk to China*. But really, 2008 ensured that the actor never again has to introduce himself to any gathering. *Singh is King*, a piping hot jalebi cooked in desi ghee, gave Kumar a permanent perch at the very top of Bollywood's food chain, spawning fashion fads and buzzwords. A much-hyped *Tashan* bombed but Kumar made news for all sorts of reasons—from a reported one film fee of Rs 71 crore to a reality show *Khatron Ke Khiladi*, which kicked off a new channel, from statements taking on the reigning badshah of Bollywood to being ambassador for IPL's Delhi Daredevils. A combination of great comedic timing and ever-new action skills, Kumar proved to be a reliable star in a difficult year. He also embodies the virtues that India's adventurous Punjabi community pride themselves on: sheer simplicity and unadulterated hard work. Most of all, his transformation, from a one-trick virtual stuntman to an all-round entertainer, showed the power of the possible.

by Kaveree Bamzai



It was Nair who took ISRO to where no Indian, man or machine, has been before—the moon and beyond.



Art of the DEAL

Amar Singh

There is a bit of Amar Singh in every political milestone of the year—from the the nuclear deal to the Batla House encounter to the cash-for-votes scandal. The flamboyant thakur began the year as a persona non grata, thrashed in Uttar Pradesh and ignored in Delhi. Even then the haughty Singh never behaved like a cringing relative, walking in late for dinners at the prime minister's house. And when he got the chance, he glided in and struck the deal of the year. When the Left tried to topple the Government, it was Singh who played saviour with his out-sourced nuclear expertise and the Samajwadi Party MPs. Now when Singh visits Batla House, it changes the political debate of the day. When he goes for an appointment with the prime minister, the media begins to speculate of a cabinet reshuffle. His charitable donations make international headlines. Ask the Congress what it finally gained from the nuclear deal and the answer is: Amar Singh.

by Priya Sahgal